

IN SHAKTI WE TRUST
SHG members at a Mission Shakti training camp in Bhubaneswar

time when states shower doles to secure women as a votebank, Mission Shakti brings them together into women's self-help groups (SHGs)—the backbone of the scheme—that make and provide various goods and services. For this, the women are trained in diverse skills, government loans are provided, repayment is insisted upon and rewarded, and business is guaranteed. The ambit of operations is wide-ranging: from farm-related activities to banking operations and public distribution system dealerships. A scheme close to the heart of Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik, Mission Shakti (MS) has provided the spark that has unleashed the hitherto untapped entrepreneurial talents of women in the hinterland. In all, 7 million women (15 per cent of the population) have benefitted, helping them to live with financial security. If one includes the privileges accruing to families, the MS scheme has touched the lives of 28 million people—half of Odisha's population.

> **"It's heartening when these women tell us how respected they feel when people address them as 'madam' "**
>
> **–SUJATHA KARTHIKEYAN** *Secretary, Mission Shakti, Odisha government*

Ultimately, by moving away from the unsustainable practice of providing doles, the MS scheme helped set in place a regenerative model: creating remunerative opportunities for rural women while also boosting the economy. "Our chief minister believes that money in the hands of women gets proper utilisation. It gets saved as well as used for family and society," says a senior member of Mission Shakti.

Though it was started in 2001, a special directorate of Mission Shakti was created under the department of